smiling shyly. A cow interrupts our conversation by dropping a big runny load two feet away.

Countless Hindus come to this ‘hallowed’ spot seeking liberation, but the Doms consider it a hell they would gladly escape. Escaping isn’t easy however—more Dom men are finishing high school, but most aren’t educated beyond middle school; they have many young and old dependents; they also lack the skills and the confidence to transition to other jobs. Lucky breaks are a big driver of upward mobility. Can I find them a job in Delhi? they ask.

Watching the spectacle on the burning ghats from the rooftop, I feel an invigorating calm, the kind that steadies and concentrates the mind. What better way to peer into nothingness and to see our common fate, evocatively laid out in the *Book of Common Prayer*: from earth to earth, ashes to ashes, dust to dust. Why, there is nothing morbid about death. It’s a basic fact of life, but one that rarely informs our daily choices and opinions. The greatest wonder, as Yudhisthira says in the Mahabharata, is that ‘each day death strikes, and we live as though we were immortal’.